

Drones

COST Much cheaper

RISK TO PERSONNEL Low, as remotely operated with no onboard crew

ENDURANCE Long endurance (MQ-9Bs can stay in the air for 40 hours)

VERSATILITY Have specialised roles: surveillance, precision strikes or electronic warfare

DECISION MAKING AI/remote operators are less adaptive in complex battlespace and more so during dogfights

SURVIVABILITY Vulnerable to air defences and expendable in swarms

LOGISTICS Easier to deploy, cheaper to maintain

TECHNOLOGY Drone technology is still too nascent to take over the role of fighter jets



The domestic aircraft maker, Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL), has been contracted by the IAF to deliver 83 indigenous Light Combat Aircraft LCA MK1A. The delivery schedule has been delayed as GE Aerospace is yet to deliver the aero-engines for these fighter jets. In September 2025, the IAF ordered another 97 LCA MK1A in the second tranche.

Gupta is optimistic that the sophistication of fighter jet technologies can be achieved in drones through sustained research and development (R&D) efforts. Till then, he believes, drones can be a force multiplier for the fighter jets.

The strongest argument in favour of manned aircraft is their reusability. A cruise missile or Kamikaze drone can be used only once and in only one role. A fighter jet, on the other hand, can carry out multiple missions and can change its role by changing its weapons package. And experts opine that one needs to factor in the full operational life of an aircraft and compare the per-strike cost of a modern multi-role fighter with a standoff missile or a kamikaze drone.

The Indian military drone market size reached \$597.88 million in 2025, according to IMARC Group's report. The market is projected to reach \$1.9 billion by 2034 by growing at a rate of 13.82%.

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JETS VS DRONES

Fighter Jets

COST They are expensive

RISK TO PERSONNEL High: pilots are exposed to mortal danger

ENDURANCE Flying hours are limited due to fuel and pilot fatigue

VERSATILITY Multirole: Can do various roles like air superiority, strike, reconnaissance, and nuclear delivery

DECISION MAKING Human in the loop. Human pilots can provide adaptability, intuition and improvisation during the mission

SURVIVABILITY Advanced stealth, electronic warfare and countermeasures make it a highly survivable platform

LOGISTICS Requires extensive maintenance, training and infrastructure

TECHNOLOGY Time-tested technology



TAKING ON THE NEIGHBOURS

China and Pakistan are both investing heavily in fighter jets and unmanned aerial assets. The Pakistan Air Force (PAF), besides expediting the induction of the Chinese-manufactured fifth-generation fighter jet J-35 (FC-31) 'Gyrfalcon', has aggressively acquired cost-effective UAVs from China and Turkey.

China has been making new fighter jet designs every 10 years and can get the sixth-generation combat jet ahead of the US. At the same time, China's unified military organisation, the People's Liberation Army, which serves as the primary armed forces of the country, is focusing on developing the capability to connect long-range drones with an intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance platform to hit enemy targets. According to estimates, China can produce 500,000 FPV (First Person View) drones monthly and ramp up production to 7,00,000 during wartime.

A per-unit cost comparison can make the competition skewed against the fighter aircraft and drones and cruise missiles would seem an obvious choice. But experts caution against such a simplified analysis. "Cost-benefit analysis in warfare is never simply a matter of unit cost. It is the effect achieved per dol-